in the past one year. Mann bounced back to win the Sangrur Lok Sabha byelection in June, while the Badal faction, now led by his son Sukhbir Singh Badal, was relegated to fifth spot. This came just three months after the SAD faced a drubbing in the assembly election, winning just three of the 97 seats it contested. But there are others too who are trying to grab a piece of the *panthic* political pie, as rebellions are becoming a routine affair in the Badal camp.

On November 9, in the election for the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) president, Akali rebel candidate Bibi Jagir Kaur managed to win 42 votes—the maximum by a challenger in the over-100-year history of the apex gurdwara body. The Badal faction did manage to get their candidate and sitting president Harjinder Singh Dhami elected with 104 votes, but only after Sukhbir camped in Amritsar for days to ensure his triumph. Even as the SAD has expelled her, Jagir Kaur remains a big threat to the Badals. A four-time former SGPC chief, she has a strong grip on religious issues and enjoys a clout among Sikhs across the world.

While Dhami is considered 'soft' on several issues concerning the *qaum* (community), including conversions, both Jagir Kaur and Sandhu believe in aggressive politics. These events signify a churn in *panthic* politics, says a Sikh preacher, adding that it will take some time to bear an outcome. That it could flare communal tensions in the border state is keeping both the Punjab government as well as the country's security agencies on tenterhooks. ■

MAYAWATI

# WOOING THE MUSLIMS

**By Prashant Srivastava**



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**FADING PRESENCE?** BSP supremo Mayawati

When did you last see Mayawati at a public meeting?' It's a common query in Uttar Pradesh's political circles whenever the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) or its supremo crops up in a conversation. The situation is such that not even her party leaders can explain why the Dalit icon and four-time chief minister has taken a back seat (except for the rare presser) in the past year or so. This, even as the party has been losing vote share with every passing election—it has just one seat now in the 403-member state assembly—and, if recent political moves are an indicator, the BSP leader seems to have no clear strategy for the future.

Mayawati, who had focused on the Brahmin vote during the assembly polls, now seems to have turned her attention to the Muslims. A logical, if not harmonious, chain of events after she held the community responsible for her party's wipeout in the election. Her grouse then was that Hindu communities (other than the Yadavs) coalesced around the BJP because Muslims chose to back the Samajwadi Party (SP) en bloc. She seems to be acting to redress that now, and inducted a few heavyweight Muslim leaders into the party, including ex-MLAs Imran Masood (from western UP) and Shah Alam aka Guddu Jamali (east UP).

**MAYAWATI'S LATEST STRATEGY OF WOOING THE MUSLIMS SEEMS TO BE AIMED MORE AT TAKING DOWN THE SAMAJWADI PARTY THAN THE RULING BJP**

The BSP chief has also taken up cudgels on behalf of the minority community on issues such as population control and madrassa surveys, saying the Yogi Adityanath-led BJP government in the state was "indulging in narrow politics and continuing to target the community" even after coming to power. Meanwhile, she seems to have abandoned the Brahmins, whom she had been so assiduously wooing before the polls. So much so that even Satish Mishra, the BSP general secretary and its Brahmin face, whom many believed to be her second-in-command, is out of